

Growing Up Online: How Trends Are Reshaping Childhood and Identity

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As we progress deeper into social media culture and the effect it has on society, I think our focus needs to shift toward the younger generation. Social media trends are spreading quicker and more ubiquitous than ever before. Kids are getting phones and joining social media at concerning young ages, inviting them in on trends and influencer culture. Since this is the first generation of kids to experience this lifestyle, we don't know what effect it may have on their future. Young people have always looked to older generations for influence and inspiration on who they want to become, but what does that look like now that they have unlimited access to their content? From my experience using social media and working around children, I think we're beginning to see these effects in real time.

I'd like to narrow in on the role that trends play in influencing the values and behaviors of younger generations. I think that through research and a case study, I could find a lot about what ways they're being affected. After looking into some reliable articles, I found great sources regarding things like demographic and behavior trends using social media, and impacts social media have on young generations. There is one article titled "Materialism, Attitudes, and Social Media Usage and Their Impact on Purchase Intention of Luxury Fashion Goods Among American and Arab Young Generations," that I will definitely use because it sounds like clear information that I'd like to learn more about. I could also conduct a study through surveying groups of individuals of all ages. Older ages can reflect on how they perceive social media trends affecting younger generations, and younger people can express how they feel personally. This would provide quantitative information that can be converted into statistics to measure.

Literature Review

In reviewing studies around trends, social media, and the youth, I found most of the findings to align with what I had originally believed. Social media trends have a significant impact on the younger generations' attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors. Several studies dove into the effects that certain trends have on young people, whether it be health and diet trends, product trends, or materialistic movements. They all follow a common theme, trends are not just short-lived interests, rather they are internalized by adolescents who adopt the values, self-identity, and behaviors that they frequently see online. These newer generations are the first to grow up in a digital environment, which is why this topic should be critically studied and discussed. However, with the rapid rate at which technology advances and changes, most of these articles seem dated, even if they were written less than 10 years ago. So, it is important to keep studying the topic, study the apps that are most popular, and give the audience relevant feedback that can be applied to today.

In-Depth Summary

My interest in this topic was driven by a personal observation of the younger generation becoming more involved in social media trend culture and developing their identity faster than ever before. Whether they use popular slang words, meme references, or trendy products found on TikTok, the youth is immersing themselves into a culture that they may not be cognitively ready to participate in. In the article, *The Sephora Kids: The Impact of Tik Tok on Consumerism of Skincare Products*, the researcher explores the influence of product trends on young consumers. This specific discussion was another big contributor to my interest in this research. The term “Sephora kid” has been circulating the internet for many years, in reference to kids under the age of 12 visiting Sephora to purchase products and other items they’ve seen on TikTok. With Sephora being a well-known *luxury* beauty store, the public's concern is regarding

how this small habit may affect children's values, expectations, and attitudes toward society as a whole.

Common Research Methods

The article uses a mixed method approach to conduct their research study. They focused on a group of Grade 9 females, highlighting how this is the ideal age group for this study due to the significant increase in focus of appearance and self-development at this age (Gadbois, 2025). There were 5 individuals who matched the intended profile and were sent the Google Forms survey. The survey consisted of 4 parts: a consent section, TikTok-based questions, skincare-based questions, and the opportunity to sign up for an interview (Gadbois, 2025). The survey provided quantitative feedback, revealing an average rating of 2.6 (on a 1-5 scale) when asked how reliable they viewed information on Tik Tok. They also found that 80% of participants see skincare related content very often, and there was an average rating of 2.6 (on a 1-5 scale) when asked if their routine had changed based on Tik Tok content. Next, they interviewed the participants to collect qualitative feedback. Participants 1 and 2 both expressed using Tik Tok as a source to check reviews on products before purchasing. However, participant 4 had an opposing experience and shared that she looks to friends and Safari over Tik Tok. The results somewhat varied from girl to girl, however, there was definitely a general theme found. Most of them find Tik Tok partially reliable, however, they were all influenced by Tik Tok recommendations to some extent.

The research on this topic has a rather even split between qualitative and quantitative methods. One example, involving the article, *Trends in Social Media: Persistence and Decay*, used statistical formulas to gather and analyze quantitative results. In this study, the researchers measured topic frequency, lifespan, retweets, and origin of content (social media vs. traditional

media). Then, developed a speculative model for topic persistence and decay (Asur et al., 2021). Therefore, in this case, they didn't necessarily use a subject group of individuals to study. Rather, they gathered about 16 million tweets over two months which were operationalized into numerical data.

However, as this is such a fluid topic, it's important at times for researchers to get insight on their participants through interviews. Relying solely on numbers can bias conclusions drawn from findings because designs have advantages, but also disadvantages. In this case, the article, *Young People's Experiences of Viewing the Fitspiration Social Media Trend: Qualitative Study*, researchers used interviews and conversations in focus groups to gather data. The participants opportunistically enrolled through spreading posters and other information on social media (Easton et al., 2017). The participants that were selected ranged from 18 to 25 years old, and considered themselves a follower of Fitspirational content on social media. After the interviewing process, the researchers found themes by developing raw data 'upwards' rather than having a preexisting theory that they're searching for (Easton et al., 2017). They found themes between participants and caught onto patterns, then refined them until a set of rich, coherent themes were established.

Definition of Key Concepts

Within the topic of *social media trends* and younger generations, there are many definitions around how we measure, observe, and analyze their meaning. Many of the articles explored how we define influence and how trends are created. For example, in *The Sephora Kids: The Impact of Tik Tok on Consumerism of Skincare Products*, research found that influence can be measured by virality (number of likes and comments) combined with the creator's identity (Gadbois, 2025). Another article, *Influence of Social Media Marketing Communications on*

Young Consumers' Attitudes, suggests that influence also varies by certain consumer demographics. They include examples such as heavy social media usage, frequent profile updaters, and people of Colored and Black population groups (Duffett, 2016). They found that all of these positively correlate with easier influence. The article, *Trends in Social Media: Persistence and Decay*, shares that trend formation depends on emotional and social resonance, suggesting that what young users connect with emotionally spreads faster (Asur et al., 2021). Along with this idea, the article, *Who Creates Trends in Online Social Media: The Crowd or Opinion Leaders*, the researchers explore the long-term analysis of popularity variation. Their findings suggest that the audience plays more significant of a role at the early stage of trend creation over opinion leaders. All of these definitions help outline what the research means and gives a clear pathway to interpret the feedback.

Common Findings

The article's findings all suggest similar outcomes. Younger generations are being significantly impacted by social media and the development of trends. A great example I found is in the article, *Materialism, Attitudes, and Social Media Usage and Their Impact on Purchase Intention of Luxury Fashion Goods Among American and Arab Young Generations*, which explores how social media impacts the perspective on materialism in particular, for younger generations. The researchers found that there is a direct link between social media use and materialistic values, with greater social media use comes higher materialism (Kamal et al., 2013). This then links higher materialism with a higher purchase intention of luxury fashion goods (Kamal et al., 2013). This is crucial to understand because kids are becoming programmed to gravitate towards and expect luxury/high-end items, which we all know is simply unrealistic. Along with this idea, the article I discussed earlier, *The Sephora Kids: The Impact of Tik Tok on*

Consumerism of Skincare Products, reflects this same idea. Their study found participants' purchases often aligned with viral brands including Drunk Elephant, Glow Recipe, and The Ordinary (Gadbois, 2025). In this case, kids want to try skincare products they view on Tik Tok which are usually pricey and probably not necessary for young aged people. Tik Tok acts as both an information and social validation platform where peer approval shapes consumption norms.

In addition to these findings, several studies also revealed why trends and social platforms create such an influence on young people. One reason, explained in the article, *Trends in Social Media: Persistence and Decay*, suggests that social media amplifies selective narratives, potentially shaping the issues and values that users, especially younger ones, see as important (Asur 2021). Social media is essentially a hub of specific patterns, language and trends that, when magnified on the massive scale that it is, can cause serious impact on the consumer. In support of this idea, the article, *Influence of Social Media Marketing Communications on Young Consumers' Attitudes*, explains how their values and behaviors are formed. Social media introduces them to a new idea, increasing their awareness, this creates a positive feeling toward the concept, which in certain cases leads to purchasing the thing to feel a part of the conversation (Duffett, 2016). All of this highlights how heavy social media usage among the youth can significantly influence what young consumers pay attention to, what they like, and how they behave.

Summary and Critique

Overall, the literature consistently shows that social media trends strongly influence young people's attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors. Across studies, researchers found that trends often shape adolescents' identities and values rather than serving as brief interests. However, much of the existing research relies on outdated platforms, older data, or generalized

observations that no longer reflect the rapidly evolving digital landscape. This limits how well the findings apply to today's social media environment, where new apps and trends emerge constantly. My proposed study will address this gap by focusing on current platforms and trend cultures that are most relevant to today's youth, using a research design that captures real-time data and reflects the fluid nature of online behavior.

Research Design

For this study, I will be using a survey research design to explore how social media trends influence the values and behaviors of younger generations. Survey research involves gathering insight from a sample of individuals through a structured questionnaire. In one article, survey research was defined as the collection of information from a sample of individuals through their responses to questions (Ponto, 2015). Survey questions are arranged to have the participants outline, describe, and explain their attitudes and beliefs on a certain topic.

I found this method to be the most suitable for the research topic because it will allow me (the researcher) to assemble a set of questions that will provide the exact information and opinions I'm searching for. I plan to use online surveys to collect data from my sample. Survey research is super effective when it comes to reaching a large and diverse sample quickly, gathering quantifiable data that is easy to interpret, and analyzing patterns across demographics. However, it has its disadvantages such as inaccurate responses due to participants disengagement or bias, misinterpretation, and lack of depth (DeFranzo, 2012).

Method Comparison

When researching previous studies done on this topic, I found that many used surveys as their method of research as well. In one article from my literature review, the author explained

that surveys were used to gather clearer distinctions than traditional methods because they could be tailored to younger participants (Duffett, 2016). However, I also found that it was useful to incorporate interviews with survey research. Depending only on numerical data from surveying can lead to biased or incomplete conclusions. For example, in another article, the researchers used interviews to conduct research. The interviews offered rich, detailed data, themes grounded in real participants' voices, and the ability to explore emerging ideas in depth, all of which are more difficult to obtain via survey (Easton et al., 2018). I think there is no better option when choosing a research method for this topic, however, I think a combination of survey and interview would be ideal.

Modality

The data will be collected through an online modality, using a digital survey distributed through social media and direct messaging. Online surveys are cost-effective, accessible, and convenient for reaching younger populations who are highly active in digital spaces. This modality also allows participants to respond anonymously, which can increase honesty in self reporting. However, with younger populations in particular, it's going to take an element of trust and patience in their responses. I think it's easy for them to be unserious a lot of the time, which is why it will be important to emphasize honesty and vulnerability in their responses. With this, selecting a strong sample will be important to maximize productive responses. It also may exclude individuals with limited internet access, though this is minimal for the target demographic of adolescents and young adults who regularly use digital platforms.

Sampling Introduction

This study will use a stratified random sampling technique. This approach involves dividing the population into key subgroups to help ensure adequate representation of each group

while also preventing over/under representation (SurveyMonkey, n.d.). I think the best way to divide the sample is by age range or social media platform usage. Age groups could be represented as 13-15, 16-18, and 19-21, for example. Social media usage could be split by app, such as TikTok, Instagram, and YouTube.

Stratified sampling ensures that each relevant subgroup of the younger population is equally represented in order to improve accuracy and generalizability of the results. This method requires more planning and organization compared to simple random sampling. It helps capture differences between digital subcultures and provides a more nuanced view of how trends shape youth behavior and values.

Sampling Comparison

I found that many prior studies used convenience sampling, often drawing participants from specific schools, online forums, or local communities. For example, in one study as part of my literature review, the participants were gathered from the same school in the same grade (Gadbois, 2025). Although convenient, such approaches risk bias and may not accurately represent diverse segments of the youth population. By using stratified random sampling, this study ensures more balanced representation across different age groups and online platforms, strengthening the readability and generalizability of its findings.

Sampling and Recruitment

When it comes to gathering participants for the study, I will use social media and personal connections to reach the younger generation. Luckily, I work with kids 4 times a week and come from a big family, so I will use my resources to share the details with them personally. The target population includes adolescents and young adults between the ages of 13 and 22 who actively engage with social media content. I think many individuals would be willing to

participate without an incentive, however, I think it's courteous to offer since they are willing to take the time to respond. I'd love to offer something that intrigues my target audience such as a gift card or sugary snack. However, I think younger people like to talk/think about themselves and are more willing to participate than an older sample population.

Stratified random sampling will be implemented by first dividing the population into subgroups based on age range: 13-15, 16-18, and 19-22. From there, I will get an understanding of the primary social media platform used within each age group. Participants will then be randomly selected from each subgroup to ensure proportional representation across the sample. If I'm unable to reach the number of participants I'd hope to, then I will have to reach out to friends, family, and social media to hopefully find more willing individuals. I may also reach people through school resources and targeted advertisements, as long as I reach adequate sample sizes.

Measures

Determining the measures on this topic is crucial in gathering the feedback I'm looking for. First, we need to measure the youths' exposure to social media trends. We can do this by asking how frequently they see new trends surfacing and whether or not they participate. Reliability can be tested by examining the consistency between responses using a Likert scale. We can measure validity because it directly captures the concept of trend exposure, operationalizing how often respondents encounter and engage with online trends. As opposed to qualitative research measures, this will provide quantitative data focused on exposure and participation in trends, allowing for clearer analysis of the relationship between trend engagement and behavioral adaptation.

Then, we have to measure participants' attitudes toward trends on social media. Again using a Likert scale, this data can be gathered by asking the individual's level of attraction toward trends. Reliability will be measured through internal consistency using Cronbach's alpha. Doing this will confirm that the items consistently reflect the core concept of trend agreement. This will also demonstrate validity by aligning with the findings from the literature review, such as specific attitudes and perceptions that trends may shape. Compared to prior studies that often measured only general online engagement, this approach provides a more precise and targeted evaluation of how trends influence individual attitudes.

Next, it will be critical to measure behavior changes. This measure may be more difficult to execute because it requires a level of introspection and self awareness that not everyone may have. However, we will have to craft questions in a way that advocates the participant to answer truthfully. Self reported behaviors may include changes in diet, fashion, or music taste due to trend adaptation. Cross checking responses to detect patterns and consistency will provide solid reliability indicators. Validity is also shown because it captures actual behavioral adoption rather than merely perceptions or opinions about trends. Compared to prior studies that relied solely on qualitative interviews, this quantitative approach provides more measurable and generalizable data on how trends translate into real-world actions.

Lastly, we will need to measure the outcome, internalized values and self identity. The questions will ask participants how or if social media influences their personal values and sense of identity through a Likert scale. In order to maximize reliability, I think a small sample should take the survey prior to the 'real' sample in order to ensure that the questions are clear and consistently interpreted. This measure demonstrates validity because it directly operationalized the internalization of values as defined in the research question. Compared to prior studies that

primarily reported subjective responses, this measure provides quantitative evidence of how trends are internalized, allowing for a more systematic analysis of their impact on young generations.

Ethical Considerations

Although all of these measures are essential to this research, there are always ethical considerations that need to be acknowledged. First, confidentiality and privacy is super important when using young people in research. When collecting their feedback, we must ensure anonymity and security. Because the survey will be taken digitally, the application being used must display strong security without identifying information collected. It's also important to guarantee consent and allow the participant to withdraw at any time. Emotional discomfort will affect the response validity and participant feedback.

Expected Findings

In what ways do trends impact the values and behaviors of younger generations? I expect to find that social media trends strongly influence the younger generations, particularly in shaping their consumer habits and personal ideologies. Based on prior research, it seems clear that regular exposure to online trends can push young people to adopt the lifestyles they see and feel pressure to fit in with mainstream behavior. I think this pattern reflects basic psychological principles. People have a desire to *fit in* and follow what's *cool*, especially at a young age. Because of this, I believe the research will show a strong correlation between trend exposure and how younger generations think and act.

To measure the quantitative feedback from the survey, I would use the mean as the central tendency because the questions use a Likert scale to record the responses. From there, the

scale can be transformed into numerical data. For measure 1: *Exposure to Trends*, an example result may be an average score of 3.8 out of 5. This would indicate fairly frequent exposure to trending content. Then, for measure 3: *Behavioral Adoption*, the mean might fall around 2.9 out of 5, suggesting that participants found a change in behavior occasionally but not super consistently. For measure 4: *Internalized Values/Self-Identity*, a possible mean could be around 3.2 out of 5, reflecting that participants moderately agreed that trends shape personal values or identity. Using the mean for each measure provides the clearest feedback of how strongly the participants experience, adopt, and internalize social media trends.

In order for the findings to support my expectations, the variables would have to be positively correlated. Meaning, if there was an increase in trend exposure then there would be an increase in behavior and values changes as well. This would tell me that the participants who frequently come across social media trends are more likely to act on them. I also think there will be a positive relationship between exposure to trends and internalized self-identity, where participants who encounter trends more often report that trends influence their self-image or decision making. Finally, I expect a significant correlation between behavior adaptation and internalized values, suggesting that those who regularly engage in trends may also be more likely to view those trends as part of their personal identity.

The strongest graph types to visualize this data would be a bar graph and a scatter plot. The bar graph would be used to display the mean score for each measure: Exposure to Trends, Behavior Adoption, and Internalized Values/Self-Identity. This visualization would make the data easily comparable by putting each mean side by side. Then, a scatterplot would be used to determine the association between each measure or variable, such as one showing the relationship between exposure to trends and behavioral adoption. In this graph, each point would

represent a participant's scores on the two measures, allowing me to visually assess whether higher exposure correlates with higher adoption. Together, these graphs would clearly show both the general patterns in the data and the relationships that support my expectations.

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Appendix: Measurement Instrument

Measure 1: Exposure to Trends (5 questions)

1. How often do you see trending content on social media? (new - very often)
2. How frequently do you participate in online challenges or viral trends? (never - very often)
3. On average, how many hours per day do you spend browsing social media platforms?
(0-1, 1-2, 2-3, 3-4, 4+)
4. In which area do you notice trends in the most: fashion, music, lifestyle, hobbies & interests, or other? (fashion, music, lifestyle, hobbies/interests, other [...])
5. How often do your friends or peers share trending content with you? (never - very often)

Measure 2: Attitudes Toward Trends (5 questions)

6. I enjoy participating in social media trends. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
7. I think social media trends are relevant to my personal interests. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
8. Following social media trends helps me feel connected to others. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
9. I believe social media trends are a waste of time. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
10. I feel positive when I engage in trends that others are also participating in. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)

Measure 3: Behavioral Adoption (5 questions)

11. I have tried a new fashion style because of a trend I saw on social media. (never - very often)

- 12. I have tried a diet or food trend after seeing it online. (never - very often)
- 13. I have participated in a social media challenge or activity after noticing it online. (never - very often)
- 14. I have purchased a product because it became popular on social media. (never - very often)
- 15. I have changed my personal routine (e.g., fitness, beauty, hobbies) due to social media trends. (never - very often)

Measure 4: Internalized Values / Self Identity (5 questions)

- 16. Trends on social media influence my sense of style or personal image. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
- 17. Following trends affects how I define my personal identity. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
- 18. I adopt trends that align with my values and beliefs. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
- 19. Social media trends affect the choices I make in my daily life. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)
- 20. Trends I participate in help me feel more like the person I want to be. (strongly disagree - strongly agree)